NIIN National Industry Innovation Network

MasterTech

CISCO Live !

Melbourne
November 9-12, 2026

In conjunction with

Innovation Central Melbourne
A collaboration led by cisco

FOUNDATION PARTNERS
cisco | LA TROBE UNIVERSITY

Welcome from the NIIN

Hello MasterTech Participants!

We hope you are all as excited as we are in the NIIN and at Innovation Central to see you here in Melbourne for the Cisco Live 2026 MasterTech Challenge! Your Cisco Live registration details will be sent to you by email before the event.

This package includes important information regarding your participation in the MasterTech Challenge. Please carefully review each document:

- **Participant Package:** (this document) provides an overview of the MasterTech program, including the program summary, daily schedule, challenge details, sponsor information and key contacts. Refer to this document to understand the program's structure, expectations and important deadlines.
- **Participant Agreement:** defines the terms and conditions of your participation, including your obligations, intellectual property rights, confidentiality, liability and program details. It also sets out our responsibilities for hosting, accommodation, transport and meals. Please make sure you understand and agree to all the terms before signing. Once you have signed, you will be invited to complete a short arrival survey to confirm your emergency contacts and dietary requirements and to provide a brief introduction of yourself. You will also be invited to a Webex space for day-to-day communication and to an MS Teams site where you can collaborate with your team members and the other Innovation Central teams.
- **Pre-Arrival Pack:** contains essential information about your accommodation at La Trobe University's Melbourne (Bundoora) campus, including check-in and check-out procedures, parking, meals, bus transport, emergency contacts and frequently asked questions. Familiarise yourself with it to ensure a smooth arrival and stay.

Melbourne arrival: participants arrive at La Trobe University Bundoora on Sunday 8 November 2026. ICM will host a welcome dinner that evening before the residential sprint begins.



Welcome cont.

Summary of key points

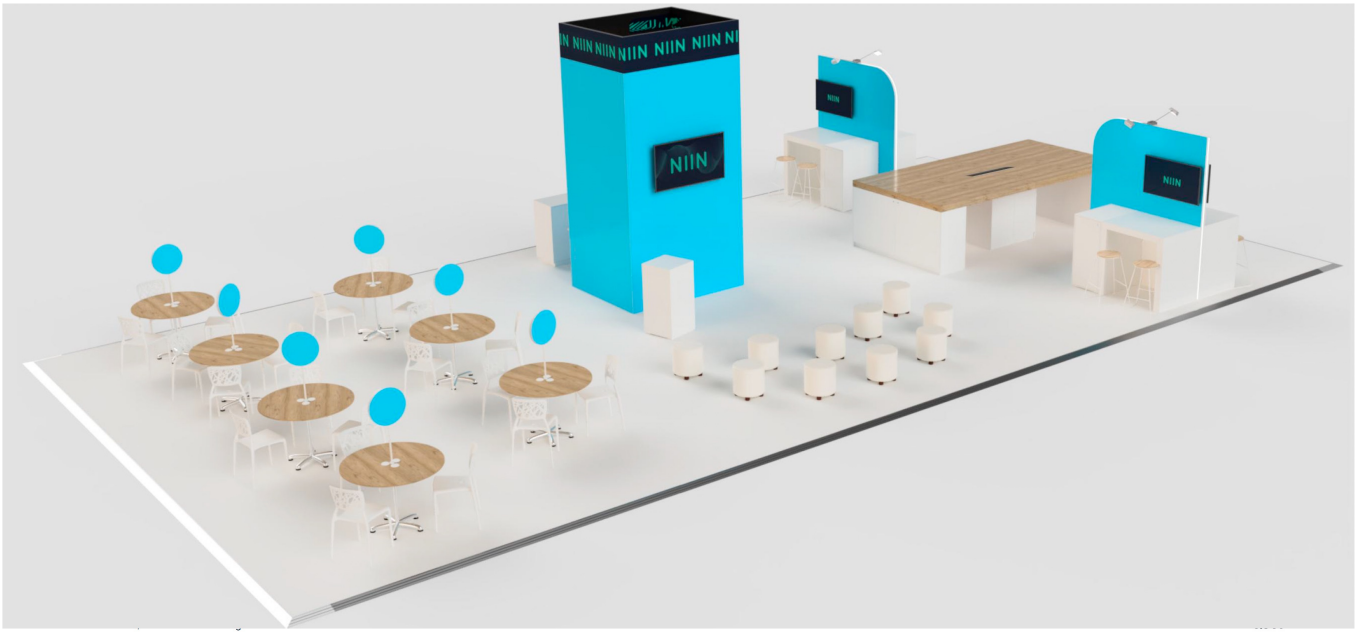
- **Program dates:** The MasterTech Challenge runs from 2 to 12 November 2026. The challenge is released on Monday 2 November, teams work in hybrid mode from their home hubs on Thursday 5 and Friday 6 November, and the residential program at Cisco Live Melbourne runs from Monday 9 to Thursday 12 November.
- **Challenge sponsor:** The 2026 industry sponsor has been confirmed and will be announced at the November 2, 2026 meeting. The sponsor will provide the challenge also on 2 November, along with resources and guidance throughout the program. Sponsor contacts, challenge assets and sponsor-specific resources will be added to the Webex and Teams spaces.
- **Team formation:** You have been placed in a team of three participants from your home city. Each Innovation Central hub sends one team, and the seven teams (Melbourne, Perth, Canberra, Adelaide, Brisbane, Sydney and Singapore) share progress across the national network and support each other through the sprint.
- **Accommodation and transport:** La Trobe University will provide accommodation at Menzies College on its Bundoora campus for all participants from Sunday 8 to Thursday 12 November 2026. Breakfast and dinner will also be provided. Transport will be arranged between the Bundoora campus and the Melbourne Convention and Exhibition Centre (MCEC) during the event. Participants are responsible for their own transport to and from the airport, and outside the dates above.
- **Preparatory activities: Mandatory preparatory activities**, including the challenge release meeting on 2 November and the hybrid sprint days on 5 and 6 November, take place before the residential program. Attendance is crucial for a successful program experience.
- **Intellectual property:** Any intellectual property created during the program will be owned by La Trobe University and assigned to the 2026 industry sponsor, as set out in the Participant Agreement. The intention is to make it easy for the sponsor to keep working with you and your Innovation Central hub on the work you produce.
- **Program expectation:** MasterTech moves quickly. Come ready to test ideas, ask for help, build working demonstrations and rehearse a clear pitch for a live audience.

Please reach out to us or your Innovation Central Director if you have any questions or need further clarification. We look forward to your participation in the MasterTech Challenge 2026!

Can't wait to see you! ICM will be hosting a welcome dinner when you all arrive on Sunday 8 November.

Kind regards,

Jeff Jones
Director, Innovation Central Melbourne | Manager, Digital Innovation Hub, La Trobe University



Participant Package

Program overview

What MasterTech is

MasterTech is a five-day, hackathon-style collaborative design sprint, run over a two-week period, designed to build technical capability and create technology solutions for impact. In 2026 it takes place at Cisco Live in Melbourne in November, with the industry sponsor, now confirmed, and to be announced on November 2, 2026..

Seven hubs in one residential sprint

Student teams from across the Innovation Central network (Melbourne, Perth, Canberra, Adelaide, Brisbane, Sydney and Singapore) converge in Melbourne. Each team of three experiments with technologies of their choice. Learning to pivot quickly in the early stages is essential to focus teams on delivering a final demonstration, within the time limits of the competition, that meets industry's needs. The residential format gives teams shared time, shared pressure and direct access to the Cisco Live environment.

A national stage at Cisco Live

Throughout the sprint, teams document their journey and present in a final exhibition showcase, with the chance to promote their solution at the National Industry Innovation Network (NIIN) stand in the World of Solutions (WoS), in front of thousands of in-person Cisco Live attendees and a much larger online audience.

Creative first, commercial second

The challenge starts with a simple question: what do you want to see in the world? Teams prototype new product experiences, drawing from a 'pantry' of available technology ingredients while navigating unforeseen challenges and market opportunities, before narrowing to a working prototype and a practical business case.

From concept to creation

Participants are challenged to try new things on a technology platform of their choice. Directions may be self-initiated or prescribed by the facilitators. Facilitators are tech savvy and can help with technical questions, and “runners” from Cisco branch offices and the Innovation Central hubs will seek out other experts attending the conference.

Experiment, fail fast, pivot

Teams are challenged to experiment, fail fast, pivot to new ideas and build multiple prototypes during the hybrid days before settling on a final product to finish.

How the facilitators help

Facilitators do not answer questions directly. Instead, they help teams shape their ideas quickly by removing barriers such as too many functions, filling knowledge gaps with suggestions, provoking thought, resolving conflict and lifting team morale.

Final showcase

The program ends with serious pitch rehearsal, a live stage presentation and an expo-style showcase that lets teams explain the prototype, the customer need and the case for taking the idea further.

The Industry challenge

Industry standard
MasterTech addresses a genuine industry problem. Teams must understand the operating context, users and constraints, then show how a credible idea can create value.

Creative first: deeper business solutions
Teams begin by asking what they want to see in the world, generating contrasting possibilities and combining technologies before business logic narrows the field. This deliberate divergence makes MasterTech like a creative catalyst: it reframes the problem, uncovers less obvious customer needs and produces more original, differentiated business solutions.

Required team output
Teams then converge on a functioning technology prototype, a business case and a stage-ready pitch. Reviewers test customer value, evidence, technical feasibility and what it would take to proceed.

Sponsor contribution
A sponsor supplies context, experts, constraints, approved data or tools and direct feedback. Their role is to sharpen the challenge and test assumptions, not prescribe the answer.

Industry scrutiny
ICM, NIIN and Cisco convene experienced reviewers. Teams face fixed deadlines, serious rehearsal, professional expectations and live evaluation.

THE STANDARD

Real problem. Working prototype.

Technology prototype.
Business case.
Live scrutiny.
Pitching to win.



Programme summary

These are the days/time participants a required.

Stage	Date	Location	Schedule (indicative)
Day 0	Mon 2 Nov	Home hubs (Webex)	**Approx. 1pm · meeting only** Sponsor and facilitators introduce the challenge. Hybrid meeting across all seven hubs (ICA, ICB, ICC, ICM, ICP, ICS, ICSg). A meeting invite will be sent.
Day 1	Thu 5 Nov	Home hubs (Webex)	**Full day** All teams connected via Webex in a hybrid workspace in their own cities. Concept testing, mentor check-ins and prototype options.
Day 2	Fri 6 Nov	Home hubs (Webex)	**Full day** All teams connected via Webex in a hybrid workspace. Select concept, define prototype plan and outline business case.
Arrival	Sun 8 Nov	La Trobe Bundoora	**Full day** Self-service travel from the airport to Bundoora; campus check-in. 6pm – ICM welcome dinner on the La Trobe Bundoora campus.
Day 3	Mon 9 Nov	ICM and Cisco Live	**Full day** 8–9am – Breakfast at Bundoora. 8am – ICM open for teams to continue work. Challenge success criteria introduced to each team. 12:15pm – Bus* to Cisco Live WoS (time for registration and lunch on arrival). NIIN workspace set-up. 7:30pm – Return to Bundoora for dinner.
Day 4	Tue 10 Nov	Cisco Live	**Full day** 7–9am – Breakfast at Bundoora. 9am – Bus* to Cisco Live WoS. Prototype build, user story, evidence and pitch rehearsal. 7pm – Return to Bundoora for dinner.
Day 5	Wed 11 Nov	Cisco Live	**Full day** 7am – Bus* to Cisco Live WoS; breakfast at WoS. Final build, serious pitch rehearsal, live showcase and awards. 6:30pm – Return to Bundoora for dinner.
Travel	Thu 12 Nov	Cisco Live	**Half day** 8–10am – Breakfast at Bundoora. 10am – Bus* to Cisco Live WoS. 11:30am–1pm – Closing BBQ at WoS. Self-service travel to the airport from WoS.

**Bus details and confirmed times will be provided in the Pre-Arrival Pack. Times shown are indicative.*

Accommodation at La Trobe University Bundoora runs Sunday 8 to Thursday 12 November 2026.







Full programme

Before the program: setup

- Webex space: MasterTech 2026. Download and install Webex before Monday 2 November.
- MS Teams space: MasterTech 2026. Download and install Teams before Monday 2 November.

Monday 2 November – Day 0: challenge release

(Teams are separate, working at their own Innovation Central sites.)

The sponsor and facilitators introduce the challenge in the shared Webex space set up for all participants, used for collaboration, communication and event notifications. Facilitators explain the sprint rhythm and confirm where teams will share working files. Whether on-site or off-site, teams attend a mandatory meeting at the start and end of each day, with constant individual interaction with facilitators and other participants. These interactions are a key part of the experience and of getting a substantial amount of work done in the five-day limit; it is like a race. A Webex "window" is open all day, every day.

Thursday 5 November – Day 1: idea testing

(Teams are separate, working at each Innovation Central site but linked in a hybrid event; the Webex window is open.)

The facilitators push teams to test a lot of ideas, and other technical advisors are available to help with issues. Teams are challenged to experiment, fail fast, pivot to new ideas and build multiple prototypes, with early mentor feedback, before settling on a direction.

Friday 6 November – Day 2: concept selection

(Teams are separate, working at each Innovation Central site but linked in a hybrid event.)

The facilitators push teams to settle on one idea, define what the prototype must prove and outline the business case. Teams are encouraged to interact with each other across the country. Facilitators help remove barriers such as too many functions and fill knowledge gaps with suggestions. They do not answer questions directly, but they help teams shape ideas quickly by provoking thought, resolving conflict and lifting team morale. Teams are not eliminated, but often the details of their ideas are.

Sunday 8 November – Travel and arrival

Participants travel to La Trobe University Bundoora, check in to their accommodation at Menzies College (see the Pre-Arrival Pack) and meet the broader cohort at the ICM welcome dinner. Weather permitting, it will be a BBQ.

Monday 9 November – Day 3: ICM and Cisco Live

Teams meet at Innovation Central Melbourne in the morning, where the challenge success criteria are introduced to each team. Around midday, teams travel by bus to Cisco Live, where each team has a workspace at the NIIN stand in the World of Solutions. Timing allows for registration on arrival and lunch at the WoS.

Tuesday 10 November – Day 4: build and rehearse

(Teams travel to Cisco Live as per Day 3.)

Expect the unexpected: on Day 4, participants are surprised by a new task announced over breakfast. Ultimately it helps teams progress their ideas. This is where divergent thinking enters each group to shape a positive story and a more detailed outcome for their work. The rest of the day focuses on prototype evidence, the customer story, business-case logic and the first serious pitch rehearsals.

Wednesday 11 November – Day 5: final pitch day

(Teams travel to Cisco Live for the final day.)

Teams put the finishing touches on their prototypes, rehearse the commercial case and pitch live on stage, then showcase their work in the style of a commercial expo or trade show. Each team must explain the problem, the working solution and what should happen next. The day closes with awards.

Thursday 12 November – Close and travel

Teams travel from Bundoora to Cisco Live for the closing BBQ and final conversations, then head home full of new purpose and new friends! Airport transfers are self-service, outside the program transport window.

Location

Accommodation: See accommodation pack

Contacts

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Challenge sponsor

Sponsor contact

To be confirmed. Sponsor mentors, challenge owners and any sponsor-specific resources will be added after the 2026 sponsor is confirmed.

Accommodation and arrival

Use the Pre-Arrival Pack for check-in details, campus information, meals, emergency contacts and transport instructions.

Program channels

Webex is the live communication channel. Teams is the working file space. Please keep both open during the hybrid and residential sprint days.

Your local hub

Your Innovation Central Director remains your first point of contact for local travel, team coordination and university-specific questions before you arrive in Melbourne.


Curtin Singapore
NIIN
National Industry
Innovation Network
UniSC
The University Of Queensland
AUSTRALIA
QUT
the university for the real world
UTS
UNIVERSITY OF CANBERRA
Curtin University
Adelaide University
Flinders University
LA TROBE UNIVERSITY
RMIT UNIVERSITY